

Section Five

Assess Candidates and Make a Decision

CHAPTER 19

When to Take a Chance on a Candidate

by Rebecca Knight

Sometimes a job description and request for applications yields less-than-ideal candidates. How do you evaluate someone you know isn't exactly right for the position? How do you know which qualities are workable and which should be nonstarters? At what point should you take a leap of faith?

What the Experts Say

First things first: You're never going to find the perfect candidate for your job opening. "The perfect candidate does not exist," says Claudio Fernández-Aráoz, a senior adviser at global executive search firm Egon Zehnder and the author of *It's Not the How or the What but the Who*. Besides, "even if the candidate does exist, it's [not a given that they would even] consider taking the job." In that sense, every applicant you're evaluating is inadequate in one way or another. "And they're not really flawed—they're just inferior to your dream candidate," says John Sullivan, professor of management at San Francisco State University and author of *1000 Ways to Recruit Top Talent*. Still, he says, all imperfect candidates are not created equal. "A bad hire can do a lot of damage."

Here are some tips on how to decide which job candidates you can work with even if they don't fulfill all the requirements.

Be data driven

When the HR department draws up the profile of the ideal candidate for your open req, the result is often "some combination of Superman, Batman, and Spider-Man," says Fernández-Aráoz. Since superheroes are in short supply in the labor market, Sullivan recommends being more objective and data driven in how you define what you seek in a candidate. "Look at the 10 people you have already doing the job. Then ask: What do the top three performers have in common? What characteristics do they share?" The answers will provide insight into the basic requirements of the role. "That's what's needed to succeed in the job, and you will assess candidates on those factors," says Sullivan.

If an applicant lacks one of the qualifications you've deemed necessary, it's an indication that they can't do the job. The objective of this exercise is to help you see more clearly which flaws are fatal and which are constructs designed by HR. For instance, you shouldn't automatically discount "someone who was a job hopper, or who was out of the workforce for two years, or who doesn't have a certain job title or degree," Sullivan says. "Some of the best web designers in the world don't have a degree in web design."

Assess capacity for learning

Even some serious inadequacies are surmountable, according to Fernández-Aráoz. “Hiring managers tend to weigh knowledge and skills, but that has many limitations,” he says. Knowledge is easy to acquire and skills can be developed, so if an otherwise promising candidate lacks a particular skill, you don’t need to write them off. “You want someone who has the capacity to continue to grow and learn,” he says. The past is precedence, adds Sullivan. Because certain skills can be learned, find out whether anyone else at the organization has ever learned that specific skill on the job and done well. It’s also worthwhile to ask candidates to describe the steps they take to learn something new. “Find out if they have a network to help them learn,” says Sullivan. An inability to learn—or, worse, a lack of interest in doing so—are flaws too great to be conquered.

Measure potential

When the drawback in question is something like a nonstandard career trajectory, your appraisal should focus on whether the candidate has the “hallmarks and predictors of potential,” says Fernández-Aráoz. These include attributes like curiosity, engagement, determination, confidence, and motivation. He recommends using structured interviews in which you ask each candidate the same set of defined questions. Of course, “you need to ask the right questions and draw the right inferences,” he says, otherwise, you risk being fooled. “Even a psychopath can be highly engaging,” he adds.

Say, for instance, you’re trying to assess the applicant’s strategic orientation. “You need to look at behavioral indicators that suggest this candidate is curious.” Fernández-Aráoz suggests asking questions like, “Tell me about a situation in which you proactively sought feedback. What did you do with the results? And what were the consequences of that?” The quality of your candidate’s response will indicate whether the flaw can be ameliorated.

Gather second (and third) opinions

And yet, don’t take those responses as gospel. It’s wise to scrutinize what your flawed applicant tells you, says Sullivan. “The world has changed,” he says. “Because of Glassdoor, people already know the questions you’re going to ask, and they know the answers, too.” That’s a boon to all applicants, but a challenge for hiring managers. Be rigorous—Sullivan recommends recording your interviews and rewatching them to validate your impressions. “Bring in outside managers for second opinions,” he adds. Sullivan is also a proponent of peer interviews. Peers who will likely be working side by side with the candidate will be able to discern the severity of the weakness. “The best people to judge are those who are already doing the job. They’re the ones who understand the job better than the manager, and they can predict success.”

Provide multiple assessments

Of course, interviews by themselves are not enough to evaluate a typical job candidate—let alone one who’s flawed. Sullivan recommends so-called “whiteboard tests” to determine whether or not their limitations would keep them from being able to do the job.

These tests, popular in Silicon Valley, aim to measure an engineer’s problem-solving skills. Candidates are given a code problem or task and a whiteboard, and they must work out their code and communicate their solution. The aim is to “give candidates a real problem they would have to solve on their first day,” says Sullivan. These tests are transferable to other industries and functions. Going in, you, the hiring manager, “know that certain parts of the solution are non-negotiable.” For instance, adds Sullivan, if you ask prospective salespeople to write up their process and in doing so, they fail to ask their customers what they want, it’s a sign that they can’t work for you.

Gauge emotional intelligence

Your assessment should not involve a consideration of whether you “want to grab a beer with your candidate” or whether “they’re nice and energetic,” says Sullivan. Indeed, those are the sort of superficial “flaws” that are famous sources of bias in the hiring process. And yet, it’s important to gauge

your flawed candidate's interpersonal skills. "People are hired because of their academic achievement and experience, but they're fired for their emotional intelligence"—or lack thereof—says Fernández-Aráoz.

Every desirable job candidate exhibits a certain degree of self-awareness, but this trait is especially important for less-than-ideal candidates. They need to know what they don't know and have good relationship-management skills and social awareness to cultivate colleagues so they can learn what they need to, adds Fernández-Aráoz. He also recommends reference checks to help you better understand the candidate. Talking to your candidate's former managers and colleagues will help you ascertain whether this person has the people skills or adaptability to thrive at your organization.

Don't compromise on character

It's also important to assess whether what you perceive as a weakness or personality flaw is, in fact, a relevant issue in terms of the role you have open, according to Fernández-Aráoz. In a lot of jobs, for instance, you think you want a candidate who exhibits optimism—"that's particularly true of sales jobs." However, if the role you're looking to fill is for a controller, optimism would be a problem. "In this case, you want a pessimistic soul who spends sleepless nights ruminating" on all the things that could go wrong.

There is, however, one exception to this rule: character flaws. "Out of principle, you should never compromise on those," he says. "If this person consistently lies, abuses people, or has lousy working habits," that's not likely to change. Besides, he adds, these things tend to come back to haunt you.

Don't succumb to pressure to hire a flawed candidate

Deciding whether or not to hire a candidate who lacks relevant experience in your industry, has an unconventional background, or has some glaring weaknesses is not easy. "We live in a world that is uncertain, ambiguous, and complex," says Fernández-Aráoz. "The fact is, you don't know what the job you're hiring for will look like in a few years," let alone how this candidate will adapt to those changes. When you've got a slate of flawed candidates, he adds, the best you can do is "figure out who is closest to the level required for the job and look at who's the most likely to develop into the role with the right type of support." But don't be impetuous or too quick to give into pressure from your boss to fill the position quickly, says Sullivan. You must weigh the cost of a vacancy with "the cost of hiring a Homer Simpson," especially for a critical, high-risk position. Simply put, don't hire someone who's just "pretty good" for a high-priority job. "It's basic risk management," says Sullivan.

Case Study: Decide What Attributes You Really Want in a Candidate and Assess Interest in Learning

Peter Miller, CEO of OptiNose, a specialty pharmaceutical company, says that inadequate job candidates are the norm, not the exception. "We all have things we're great at, and things we're not so great at," he says. "You won't have a perfect candidate coming through the door and—even after years of development—you won't have a perfect, well-rounded employee."

Earlier in his career, Peter cofounded Take Care Health—a company that manages convenient care clinics and worksite-based health centers—and he needed to hire a chief nurse practitioner officer to lead the nursing organization. Before he and his business partner, Hal Rosenbluth, even reviewed their slate of candidates, they decided on the nonnegotiable attributes of the winning candidate.

"We said: 'What is mission critical to what we're trying to do?' And we realized that we needed someone who could inspire and motivate the other nurse practitioners on the team and someone who had an unrelenting focus on patients."

Peter says they received a great deal of interest in the job. "We had a lot of applications from heads of nurse practitioner organizations and from nurses who were running major parts of hospitals," he recalls.

But the conventional candidates seemed to be missing something. Instead, he was drawn to an unorthodox résumé from Sandy Ryan. Sandy, a former Air Force major, was a nurse in a family clinic.

“She had leadership experience—but not in the environment we were looking for,” he says. “And she had zero business experience.”

Despite these weaknesses, Peter and Hal brought her in for interviews. “I put the job description in front of her, and I said, ‘Tell me about what you’re going to be exceptional at; and conversely, tell me what you’re going to struggle with.’”

Sandy discussed her medical expertise and her patient caretaking abilities. She was also open and honest about her flaws and her lack of business acumen. “Sandy talked about how she was going to go about learning the business and the steps she would take to look for help,” says Peter. “It was clear that she was curious, passionate, and driven, and had a capacity to learn.”

Peter says that his assistant at the time, Tammy McCauley, who now serves as chief administrative officer at OptiNose, also provided a favorable opinion of Sandy. “Candidates can be very good at fooling you—they’re trying to get the job, but I am always interested to hear how they interacted with Tammy and her impressions,” he says. “I don’t hire anyone unless Tammy has given her stamp of approval.”

Sandy got the job and has been a “star in the industry,” says Peter.

**Names and identifying details have been changed.*

Rebecca Knight is a journalist who writes about all things related to the changing nature of careers and the workplace. Her essays and reported stories have been featured in the *Boston Globe*, *Business Insider*, the *New York Times*, BBC, and the *Christian Science Monitor*. She was shortlisted as a Reuters Institute Fellow at Oxford University in 2023. Earlier in her career, she spent a decade as an editor and reporter in New York, London, and Boston.

Adapted from “When to Take a Chance on an Imperfect Job Candidate” on hbr.org, March 8, 2021 (product #H0685J).

CHAPTER 20

Seven Strategies for Better Group Decision-Making

by Torben Emmerling and Duncan Rooders

When you need to hire a new employee, you'll likely need to work with a recruiter and other colleagues in the assessment and selection process. More perspectives will help you make a better recruitment decision, right? Not necessarily. There's no guarantee that more people mean a better outcome. An overreliance on hierarchy, an instinct to prevent dissent, and a desire to preserve harmony leads many groups to fall into *groupthink*.¹

Misconceived expert opinions can quickly distort a group decision. Individual biases can easily spread across the group and lead to outcomes far outside individual preferences. And most of these processes occur subconsciously.

This doesn't mean that groups shouldn't make decisions together—especially when it comes to hiring—but you do need to create the right process for doing so. Based on behavioral and decision science research and years of application experience, we have identified seven simple strategies for more effective group decision making:

Keep the group small when you need to make an important decision

While the involvement of many people can help to develop a diverse perspective, large groups are much more likely to make biased decisions. For example, research shows that groups with seven or more members are more susceptible to confirmation bias when it comes to making decisions.² The larger the group, the greater the tendency for its members to research and evaluate information in a way that is consistent with preexisting information and beliefs. By keeping the group to between three and five people, a size that people naturally gravitate toward when interacting, you can reduce these negative effects while still benefiting from multiple perspectives.

Choose a heterogenous group over a homogenous one (most of the time)

Various studies have found that groups consisting of individuals with homogeneous opinions and beliefs have a greater tendency toward biased decision-making.³ Teams that have potentially opposing points of view can more effectively counter biases. However, context matters.⁴ When trying to complete complex tasks that require diverse skills and perspectives, such as conducting research and designing processes, heterogeneous groups may substantially outperform homogeneous ones. But in repetitive tasks requiring convergent thinking in structured environments, such as adhering to safety procedures in flying or health

care, homogenous groups often do better. As a leader, you need first to understand the nature of the decision you're asking the group to make before you assemble a suitable team.

Appoint a strategic dissenter (or even two)

One way to counter undesirable groupthink tendencies in teams is to appoint a “devil’s advocate.” This person is tasked with acting as a counterforce to the group’s consensus. Research shows that empowering at least one person with the right to challenge the team’s decision-making process can lead to significant improvements in decision quality and outcomes.⁵ For larger groups with seven or more members, appoint at least two devil’s advocates to be sure that a sole strategic dissenter isn’t isolated by the rest of the group as a disruptive troublemaker.

Collect opinions independently

The collective knowledge of a group is an advantage only if it’s used properly. To get the most out of your team’s diverse capabilities, we recommend gathering individual opinions before people share their thoughts within the wider group. You can ask team members to record their ideas independently and anonymously in a shared document, for example. Then ask the group to assess the proposed ideas, again independently and anonymously, without assigning any of the suggestions to particular team members. By following such an iterative process, teams can counter biases and resist groupthink. This process also makes sure that perceived seniority, alleged expertise, or hidden agendas don’t play a role in what the group decides to do.

Provide a safe space to speak up

If you want people to share opinions and engage in constructive dissent, they need to feel they can speak up without fear of retribution. Actively encourage reflection on and discussion of divergent opinions, doubts, and experiences in a respectful manner. There are three basic elements required to create a safe space and harness a group’s diversity most effectively. First, focus feedback on the decision or discussed strategy, not on the individual. Second, express comments as suggestions, not as mandates. Third, express feedback in a way that shows you empathize with and appreciate the individuals working toward your joint goal.

Don’t overrely on experts

Experts can help groups make more informed decisions. However, blind trust in expert opinions can make a group susceptible to biases and distort the outcome.⁶ Research demonstrates that making them part of the decision-making can sway the team to adapt their opinions to those of the expert or make overconfident judgments.⁷ Therefore, invite experts to provide their opinion on a clearly defined topic, and position them as informed outsiders in relation to the group.

Share collective responsibility

Finally, the outcome of a decision may be influenced by elements as simple as the choice of the group’s messenger. We often observe a single individual being responsible for selecting suitable group members, organizing the agenda, and communicating the results. When this is the case, individual biases can easily influence the decision of an entire team. Research shows that such negative tendencies can be effectively counteracted if different roles are assigned to different group members based on their expertise.⁸ Moreover, all members should feel accountable for the group’s decision-making process and its final outcome. One way to do that is to ask the team to sign a joint responsibility statement at the outset, leading to a more balanced distribution of power and a more open exchange of ideas.

Of course, following these steps doesn't guarantee a great recruitment decision and ultimately a great hire. However, the better the quality of the decision-making process and the interaction between the group members, the greater your chances selecting someone who positively contributes to your organization.

Torben Emmerling is the founder and managing partner of Affective Advisory and the author of the D. R.I.V.E. framework for behavioral insights in strategy and public policy. He is a founding member and nonexecutive director on the board of the Global Association of Applied Behavioural Scientists (GAABS) and a seasoned lecturer, keynote speaker, and author in behavioral science, decision science, and applied consumer psychology.

Duncan Rooders is the CEO of a Single Family Office and a strategic adviser to Affective Advisory. He is a former B747 pilot, a graduate of Harvard Business School's Owner/President Management program, and the founder of Behavioural Science for Business (BSB), advising several international organizations in strategic and team and financial decision-making.

Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, September 22, 2020 (product #H05VFP).

NOTES

1. Irving Janis, "Groupthink," in *A First Look at Communication Theory*, ed. Em Griffin (New York: McGrawHill, 1991), 235–246.

2. Dieter Frey, Stefan Schulz-Hardt, and Dagmar Stahlberg, "Information Seeking Among Individuals and Groups and Possible Consequences for Decision Making in Business and Politics," in *Understanding Group Behavior*, vol. 2, *Small Group Processes and Interpersonal Relations*, ed. Erich H. Witte and James H. Davis (Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates, 1996), 211–225.

3. Stefan Schulz-Hardt, Dieter Frey, Carsten Lüthgens, and Serge Moscovici, "Biased Information Search in Group Decision Making," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 78, no. 4 (2000): 655–669. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.78.4.655>.

4. Norbert L. Kerr, Robert J. MacCoun, and Geoffrey P. Kramer, "When Are N Heads Better (or Worse) Than One?: Biased Judgment in Individuals Versus Groups," in *Understanding Group Behavior*, vol. 2, *Small Group Processes and Interpersonal Relations*, ed. Erich H. Witte and James H. Davis (Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates, 1996), 105–136.

5. David M. Schweiger, William R. Sandberg, and James W. Ragan, "Group Approaches for Improving Strategic Decision Making: A Comparative Analysis of Dialectical Inquiry, Devil's Advocacy, and Consensus," *Academy of Management Journal* 29, no. 1 (1986): 51–71, <https://doi.org/10.5465/255859>.

6. Dilek Önköl, Paul Goodwin, and Mary Thomson et al., "The Relative Influence of Advice from Human Experts and Statistical Methods on Forecast Adjustments," *Journal of Behavioral Decision Making*, 22 (2009): 390–409, <https://doi.org/10.1002/bdm.637>.

7. Andreas Mojzisch, Stefan Schulz-Hardt, Rudolf Kerschreiter, and Dieter Frey, "Combined Effects of Knowledge About Others' Opinions and Anticipation of Group Discussion on Confirmatory Information Search," *Small Group Research* 39, no. 2 (2008): 203–223, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1046496408315983>.

8. Cass R. Sunstein and Reid Hastie, “Making Dumb Groups Smarter,” *Harvard Business Review*, December 2014.

CHAPTER 21

A Scorecard for Making Better Hiring Decisions

by Ben Dattner

Most companies and individuals make less-than-stellar investments in human capital, particularly when using interviews to evaluate candidates. Why? Because people are biased, emotional, and inconsistent when interviewing.

Using the model of detection theory, there are four basic scenarios for interviewing and hiring. The first is that a “good” candidate is hired, constituting a “hit.” If the “good” candidate is not hired, this is a “miss.” In the event that a “bad” candidate is not hired, this is a “correct rejection.” And if a “bad” candidate is hired, this is a “false positive.”

Interviewers tend to be most concerned with trying to avoid false positives, as hiring a candidate who doesn’t work out can be highly problematic. It’s rare that an interviewer ever finds out about a miss (e.g., that a candidate who was not hired became very successful somewhere else). Your “hit rate” can be calculated by the ratio of your hits and correct rejections to your misses and false positives.

How can you improve your hiring hit rate? An interview scorecard can provide a quantitative basis for comparison between interviewers, enabling you to validate your perceptions with your colleagues and learn where your ratings may be outside of the norm. By correlating your predictions with candidates’ actual performance on the job, you can also get quantitative feedback about your accuracy at assessing different criteria. Only by developing awareness of our own evaluative interview biases is it possible to correct them.

To create an interview scorecard, write down ratings along five or so applicable criteria (see table 21-1), and then periodically revisit them. Discuss and debate your candidate ratings with colleagues to assess and improve your individual and collective accuracy. You might learn that you are good at assessing technical ability, but less accurate in your evaluation of leadership skills. Or that a colleague is too lenient on some criteria and too stringent on others.

TABLE 21-1

Interview scorecard

Candidate name _____

Position interviewed for _____

Date _____

CRITERION	INTERVIEW RATING (1- 5)	PERFORMANCE RATING AFTER HIRE (1-5)	GAP	COMMENTS/LESSONS LEARNED
1. Technical ability				
2. Leadership skills				
3. Interpersonal/team skills				
4. Presentation skills				
5. Organizational citizenship				

OVERALL STRENGTHS:	OVERALL CONCERNS:	WHAT WOULD HELP THIS CANDIDATE BE MOST SUCCESSFUL IN THE ROLE?
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____

Source: Dattner Consulting, LLC.

Assess Candidates and Make a Decision

When used properly and consistently, interview scorecards help level the playing field for candidates, create a quantitative basis for comparison and validation, and enable you and your organization to make better hiring decisions over time.

Ben Dattner is an executive coach and organizational development consultant, and the founder of New York City-based Dattner Consulting, LLC.

Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, February 4, 2016 (product #H02NFH).

CHAPTER 22

Why You Should Invest in Unconventional Talent

by Debbie Ferguson and Fredrick “Flee” Lee

What do an administrative assistant, exercise physiologist, and music composition major have in common? They are all among our top hires for software developer roles.

Many stellar engineers have no formal certifications or degrees; some didn’t go to college. We believe that there’s no single “best” route to a role. Often, less-traveled roads can provide invaluable experience and unexpected perspectives.

We’ve walked these unconventional paths ourselves as a self-taught hacker and a first-generation college graduate, respectively. We’ve worked at companies where we were the “only” on a team—the only Black engineer (Flee), the only trans engineer (Debbie), or the only woman (Debbie)—and we’ve been told, implicitly and explicitly, that we don’t fit the mold. We’ve been in the room when hiring committees passed up qualified candidates in favor of those with more traditional pedigrees.

Those experiences fueled our passion to hire differently and to encourage other leaders to do the same.

The importance of building diverse organizations has been well established. Diversity is linked to greater innovation and performance; McKinsey found that more diverse companies had higher profits than their more homogeneous counterparts.¹

In contrast, a lack of diversity can lead to convergent thinking. People who share training and experiences tend to reach a consensus faster because they view problems the same way.² However, the long-term impact is less beneficial, resulting in narrower thinking and products that don’t meet their potential.

Building teams with different skill sets and life experiences requires intention. By designing inclusive hiring practices—and letting go of the notion that there’s one ideal candidate type for a role—we can create more opportunities for a range of candidates who are more than capable. Here’s how.

Focus on potential rather than pedigree

We asked developers at Gusto to talk about their backgrounds and noticed a common theme: Many discovered a passion for building software through a mix of self-study, experimentation, and formal classes. Others found their love of engineering through seemingly unrelated jobs, including being a paralegal and a video editor.

We both began our careers with different tool sets than we use today. Many, if not most, skills can be taught on the job; what matters is the desire and core capabilities to succeed. Jobs are changing so rapidly that adaptable learners are in high demand.³ Many top companies, including Google, Apple, and

Bank of America, now focus less on “official” qualifications—many are no longer requiring traditional degrees—and we’re excited to see this trend continue.⁴

The truth is that the skills that seem ideal for a role today may no longer even be a fit in a year. When you’re screening and interviewing candidates, look for ways to explore the capabilities that will enable the individual to thrive as everything around them changes. Consider asking questions like the following:

- **What were you doing the last time you looked at a clock and realized you had lost all track of time?** An open-ended question like this can help you uncover intellectual curiosity and understand what motivates someone.
- **Describe a project you’re proud of that involved working closely with other people.** Give - candidates the opportunity to demonstrate self-awareness and teamwork; for example, by discussing how they raised up their team and vice versa.

Look for the sparkles in your talent pool

Unconventional hiring is an exercise in holding up diamonds to the light. You’re training your eye to spot what glitters, which might be someone’s volunteer or advocacy work, music, writing, or an insightful social media thread.

One of our most prolific interviewers bases her questions on a candidate’s LinkedIn profile—but not the section you might think. She jumps to interests and the people they follow, rather than starting with education, endorsements, or even experience. Those sparks can be more telling than a job title.

Events and contests can also help you expand your talent pool to people who may not yet see themselves as experienced professionals. We find coding competitions to be rich sources of passionate and unconventional talent. One of our best hires for security engineering was a financial analyst who excelled in a cybersecurity contest. In these contests, sparkling doesn’t necessarily mean winning. Runners-up often make strong candidates because they’re less focused on rushing to complete a challenge and more interested in methodically solving a problem.

Help unconventional candidates envision themselves at your company

Recruiting nontraditional hires sometimes involves convincing someone they can flourish in a role they can’t yet imagine. Job descriptions, your company’s LinkedIn profile, and your website’s careers section are all venues to reinforce your culture and ethos. Use those opportunities to authentically describe what it’s like to work at your company, then consider how those descriptions may resonate with candidates with different career experiences and backgrounds. For example, look for ways to minimize jargon; insider language could discourage candidates from applying, even if they have a real shot.

Another way to welcome unconventional applicants is to paint the big picture of a role rather than a checklist of specialized skills, degrees, or years of experience. When crafting job descriptions, we focus on what the candidate can expect to do day-to-day and what we’re looking for at a high level, such as an “interest in complex product development problems.” If we mention specific programming languages, we’ll clarify that you don’t need to know them because there will be training on the job.

When writing job descriptions, focus on the essential components of a given role. For every requirement or responsibility, keep asking why it’s crucial. For example, when we’re writing the job description for an engineering role, we could require that applicants have experience with Amazon Web Services, the cloud service provider we use—but why? We need engineers who understand cloud computing, and the security needs and scale that come with it. That experience with cloud services is

essential, but a specific provider is not. We need someone who knows how to drive a car, not someone who knows how to drive a particular make and model. The job description should reflect that; otherwise, we narrow the applicant pool unnecessarily.

With artificial intelligence likely to reshape nearly every task and job over the coming years, your employees must be resilient and adaptable. During interviews, ask for examples of where a candidate had to handle a significant and unexpected change. Listen to whether the candidate leaned into the challenge, took ownership, and worked through options to achieve a good outcome. Often, unconventional candidates have faced and overcome a variety of challenges in their careers and lives.

We encourage every hiring manager to think beyond the confines of traditional hiring. Prepare for new hires who shake up your worldview and challenge assumptions about career paths. Continue investing in their growth. Together, chart an unconventional course toward the destination: an inclusive workplace for extraordinary talent.

Debbie Ferguson is CEO and founder of GratiSports. Previous roles include vice president at Gusto, senior engineering executive at Google, an early leader at Facebook, and founder and CEO of Ignite Logic.

Fredrick “Flee” Lee has over 20 years of experience leading global information security and privacy efforts at major financial services companies and technology startups, including as Chief Security Officer at Square and most recently as Chief Security Officer and Head of IT at Gusto. Flee is currently CISO at Reddit. He oversees Reddit’s Privacy and Security teams responsible for identifying and mitigating risks and challenges around information security, privacy, and compliance. Flee is a proud Southerner, raised in Mississippi, and holds a bachelor’s degree in computer engineering from the University of Oklahoma. In his spare time, Flee enjoys rock climbing, snowboarding, mountain biking, road cycling, and powerlifting, and is a passionate Redditor, lurking in r/MMA, r/Awwducational, r/selfhosted, and r/netsec.

Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, May 25, 2021 (product #H06DVA).

NOTES

1. Sundiatu Dixon-Fyle, Kevin Dolan, Dame Vivian Hunt, and Sara Prince, “Diversity Wins: How Inclusion Matters,” [mckinsey.com](https://www.mckinsey.com/featured-insights/diversity-and-inclusion/diversity-wins-how-inclusion-matters), May 19, 2020, <https://www.mckinsey.com/featured-insights/diversity-and-inclusion/diversity-wins-how-inclusion-matters>.

2. Richard P. Larrick, “Broaden the Decision Frame to Make Effective Decisions,” in *Handbook of Principles of Organizational Behavior: Indispensable Knowledge for Evidence-Based Management*, 2nd edition, ed. Edwin A. Locke (Chichester, UK: John Wiley & Sons Ltd, 2009), <https://sites.duke.edu/larrick/files/2014/09/2009-Larrick-Handbook-of-Principles-of-Org-Behavior.pdf>.

3. Darren Shimkus, “Why Your Next Hire Should Be an Adaptable Learner,” HR Dive, August 22, 2017, <https://www.hrdive.com/news/why-your-next-hire-should-be-an-adaptable-learner/503190/>.

4. Glassdoor Team, “33 Companies Actively Hiring Right Now,” Glassdoor, July 3, 2024, <https://www.glassdoor.com/blog/companies-actively-hiring/>.

CHAPTER 23

Don't Hire a Former Employee Before Asking These Questions

by Marlo Lyons

Many employees are on the move, looking for that next opportunity. Perhaps they want a bigger challenge, more money, or believe they need to leave their current company to advance their career. But what if they leave your company and realize the new opportunity wasn't as great as they thought, or they left years ago, gained new skills, and now want to come back? Should you hire them?

Rehiring a former employee, known as a *boomerang*, may seem like the easy answer because they already know the company culture, business nuances, and people, but there are several reasons why they might not be the right person for the job. Here are five questions managers should ask themselves before hiring a former employee.

Am I hiring the boomerang employee because it seems like the easy option?

The employee knows the company, but is the new job exactly the same as the one they left? Most employees will come back to an employer for a different or more senior role. Consider how they'll adjust to a different role and whether their colleagues will see them as capable of that higher-level position. Check in with their previous manager (if applicable), HR, and cross-functional stakeholders not only about whether the employee should be considered for rehire, but also about their soft skills and ability to adjust to new and dynamic situations. This will help you foresee any roadblocks to the boomerang's success in the new role.

Then think about how they'll fit into the culture of your team. Is it the same team, or has it changed or grown since they left? If it's a new team, how will the boomerang fit in with the current employees? Will they be managing any former colleagues who were previously peers? And how will that impact the team dynamics? What will you need to do to ensure a smooth transition for the boomerang and the team?

Finally, do you equate "easier" with "no ramp time?" You may think the boomerang doesn't need much onboarding, especially if they're returning to the same team, but companies, teams, and processes grow and change, and boomerangs deserve the same amount of ramp time as any new employee. If they get back into the swing of things quickly, then great!

Does the boomerang bring the right skills and capabilities to advance the business?

You're familiar with the skills and capabilities the employee had before they left the company. What new skills and experience have they gained since leaving? Do those skills match the job description and help advance the business, or are their current and previous skills obsolete compared to where the company is headed? Making sure the boomerang has the skills that fit the job responsibilities and business needs is critical to moving the company forward.

Is unconscious bias influencing me?

When employees leave a company, they often keep in touch with former colleagues. If you've remained friendly with the boomerang employee and talked to them about a role you're hiring for, there's a chance unconscious bias contributed to how you designed the job description. Consider whether you drafted the job description objectively or wrote it to match the potential boomerang's experience and level, which might not match the business needs.

Unconscious bias could also influence how you manage this friend-employee. Being a "frien-ager"—a friend who becomes a manager—can lead to inequity on the team. What will you do to combat unconscious bias in promotions, performance reviews, and overall strategic conversations?

When a high school friend hired me at NBC, we had a detailed conversation about our expectations as a manager and employee. I was fortunate, because he was a great boss and provided ample feedback and guidance. If I saw him and his family on the weekends, we did not discuss work or any employee; and when in the office, we didn't discuss any personal information outside of a group setting. It was a delicate balance that required a level of maturity to not make others feel excluded from "inside jokes" or make them feel that their relationships with the manager were any less meaningful than mine.

The best way to combat unconscious bias is to understand what it is, acknowledge it can exist, and listen to all employees (including the boomerang) equally. A transparent, detailed conversation with all team members about how you expect to behave as their manager and what you expect of them—to tell you if you faltered in your efforts to manage fairly—will help your employees feel empowered to discuss any perceived unfairness and will combat divisiveness within your team.

Have expectations of the "what" and the "how" changed since the employee left?

Your company may have grown or changed since the former employee left, and that means the expectations of your team have changed. When they previously worked for your company, the boomerang may have exceeded all expectations on deliverables and been beloved by everyone who knew them. But if the expectations are different or higher now, will they be able to deliver as effectively as before?

Communicate any different or higher expectations to the boomerang throughout the hiring process. They need to be able to determine if the role is right for them and whether they can be successful based on the changed expectations. Without this transparency, you won't be able to have a mutual understanding of what success looks like in the role.

Will I be able to provide opportunities that ensure retention long term?

As a hiring manager, it's your job to understand what's important to your employees (in other words, their values). If a former employee wants to come back, it's important to have an honest conversation about what they're looking for, why the role could be fulfilling for them, and what it will take to keep them engaged long term. For example, if the employee left to gain new skills, how will you ensure they can use those skills in this new role? What else do they want to learn, and can you provide that opportunity? If the employee left because of a lack of connection with their previous boss, will they be able to engage with you successfully? If they left for a higher title or more money, will they feel stifled again after a short period of time without a promotion or jump in salary? Without understanding the employee's values, it will be hard to provide opportunities that ensure long-term retention.

Boomerangs can provide great value to an organization based on their previous experience and the new perspectives and skills gained at another employer. It's up to managers to ensure the boomerang will be able to bring that value in the new role.

Marlo Lyons is a career, executive, and team coach, as well as the award-winning author of *Wanted—A New Career: The Definitive Playbook for Transitioning to a New Career or Finding Your Dream Job*. You can reach her at marlolyonscoaching.com.

Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, January 26, 2022 (product #H06TT6).